

Tech Snippets

Press report on China's immersion DUV tools is unlikely to impact ASML's earnings trajectory in the mid-term

The News: An unconfirmed article in The Information [reports](#) that an unnamed state-backed Chinese manufacturer has started producing domestically developed immersion deep ultraviolet (DUV) lithography machines, a segment dominated by ASML. Initial output is set to be limited, with roughly five machines this year and about 20 in 2027. Deliveries are expected in 2026 to major domestic chipmakers including SMIC, Hua Hong Semiconductor and ChangXin Memory Technologies. Immersion DUV is the most advanced lithography category still accessible to Chinese firms after export curbs blocked EUV systems; a domestic EUV tool reportedly remains at the prototype stage. The report notes the machines still trail on performance and reliability and require further testing before mass production. ASML shares are declining more than 8%, underperforming the broader SOX Index which is down ~3.5%.

Our Take: We believe that the market reaction seems disproportionate to what has been indicated in the report. Producing a handful of immersion DUV tools is not the same as producing tools that can be used for high-volume manufacturing, where *yield, overlay, throughput and reliability over thousands of wafer runs* are what matter. China has manufactured lower-end i-line lithography equipment for a few years already without any impact on ASML's market share in front-end production. This is a useful reference point, as it takes a long time to go from "a working machine" to "a production-worthy machine". Chinese manufacturers will indeed buy the prototype local tools, but to replace ASML tools with these tools would be very negative for production capabilities and these companies, we believe, are unlikely to do this unless the tools are competitive with ASML tools on the key metrics mentioned above. We would highlight that ASML itself had a "working" EUV tool in the late 2000s, but a tool that could be used for production only in 2018 and used for significant high volume production only in the 2020s. That said, this is another data point in China's equipment self-sufficiency story, and it raises the long-term risk to ASML's China revenue. We would, however, highlight that ASML's equipment peers in deposition, metallization, epitaxy, etc. already have viable local competitors in China. However, at the leading edge, none of these peers have lost significant share and these peers are trading at a premium to their valuation in the previous semiconductor cycle. Thus, we do not see a reason why ASML should be treated differently from its US/Japanese peers. We see the share price move as a sentiment-driven de-rating on the headline rather than a change in ASML's earnings trajectory.

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